

community-level audio portals could be used as voice-based bulletin boards. By managing the size of the user base, and ensuring a manageable user adoption rate by limiting publicity to word of mouth, communities could eliminate the need for moderation by making sure everyone on the platform was known by the others and therefore accountable to the community.

Several communities can then choose to link their platforms, either by sharing content, or by simply listening to each other. This will eventually lead to an organically expanding network, where people can choose which deployments they want to subscribe to, much in the same way as Internet users subscribe to different forums and websites. This would also ease the burden on centralised deployments already in existence, since they could then simply trawl the community bulletin boards for usable content, rather than filter out unusable content on their own incoming stream. As you can see from Figure 5, the hyperlocal model offers more avenues for collaboration and the cross-fertilisation of ideas between communities than the centralised model.

A word of caution: This approach is still experimental, and needs several more deployments before it can be considered a best practice. However, for communities interested in improving their information access and level of participation in mainstream society, this is a very worthwhile experiment to take on. Both systems described here can be installed on a mid-range notebook computer. The software is all open source and free for non-commercial use. Mobile interfaces like GSM gateways and mobile ATAs are relatively cheap—a Matrix SETU ATA 211G

would cost roughly US\$ 120, and the Mobigater is priced at about US\$ 50. The total cost of setting up a local IVR installation and running it through a year, including the cost of connectivity, is typically less than US\$ 200 a year.

Of course, the most important thing to remember while setting up an alternative communication platform is that while technology will certainly provide the tools, the key to success is to build a strong community around your platform, and quickly demonstrate value to the community from participating. This is where most of the hard work lies.

It would be interesting to see how well the open source community in India takes to these projects and how quickly the hyperlocal model can be tested with several more installations. 

References

The Swara Project on GitHub: <https://github.com/mojolab/swara>
 The Swara Community: <http://swara.mojolab.org/>
 CGNet Swara: <http://cqnetswara.org>
 The Freedom Fone Project: <http://freedomfone.org>

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